



P 31 · 36 PAGES, BROADER THAN JUST PUMPING

A Returning-to-Work Plan

Thirty-six pages for the broader return-to-work transition. The conversation with your manager. The first-day-back plan. The morning routine, redesigned for two-person logistics. The "I am also a different worker now" page. The ninety-day check-ins. Pairs with the Back-to-Work Pumping Planner if you are also feeding.

Soothemade Notes

A SMALL APOTHECARY OF PRINTABLES · MADE SLOWLY

A note before you start

The return to work after a baby is one of the least-supported transitions in modern life. The workplace assumes you are roughly the same person who left. You are not. The body has done a thing. The hormones are doing a thing. The identity is shifting. The schedule has been rebuilt from scratch.

This planner is the structured version of the conversation no one had with you about what to expect.

The Back-to-Work Pumping Planner (P17) handles feeding logistics. This is the broader question: the schedule, the identity, the meetings, the new dynamic with whoever you used to be at work.

Soothemade

This is a planning tool, not employment law advice. For specific questions about leave, accommodation, or discrimination, please talk to HR, an employment lawyer, or your state's department of labor.

The two-weeks-before checklist

Print this. Work through it in the two weeks before your return.

TWO WEEKS BEFORE RETURN

CHILDCARE

- ☐ Confirmed start date with daycare / nanny
- ☐ Trial day done (HIGHLY recommended)
- ☐ Backup plan named (the sick-day plan)
- ☐ Daycare handoff pack (P32) printed and ready

WORK

- ☐ Conversation scheduled with manager about return
- ☐ Out-of-office turned off (set for two weeks longer than you think you need)
- ☐ Email password reset done in advance (you will have forgotten it)
- ☐ Calendar reviewed for the first two weeks back
- ☐ Cleared the first week of any non-essential meetings
- ☐ A "what changed while I was out" briefing scheduled for week 1 (30 minutes max, from a trusted colleague)

HOME

- ☐ Morning routine practiced (see template below)
- ☐ Lunches planned for the first week
- ☐ Childcare drop-off route practiced in real time
- ☐ Partner / household logistics conversation done

PHYSICAL

- ☐ Work clothes tried on (you may need new ones, the body is what it is)
- ☐ Comfortable shoes that you can stand in
- ☐ A small bag of "in case" items for the office (extra nursing pads, snacks, a backup top)

EMOTIONAL

- ☐ The first-day-back script practiced (page below)
- ☐ A safe person identified to text on the hard day

□ A specific small "I made it" reward planned for the end of the first week

The manager conversation

Three scripts, depending on the situation.

Script 1, the supportive manager

"Thanks for setting this time. A few things I wanted to flag for the return:

- I'll be back on _____ at _____ AM.
- My calendar is open by _____.
- I'd like to ease into meetings the first week.
one or two a day, max.
- [If pumping: I'll need three short pump breaks during the day. I'll put them on my calendar.]
- I'd appreciate a brief catch-up with you and the team so I can get up to speed without making everyone repeat themselves.
- I'm planning to start on full days but will reassess after the first two weeks.

Is there anything you'd like me to know before I'm back?
Any changes I should be aware of?"

Script 2, the manager who has not been through this

"I appreciate you wanting to support the return. A few things that will help us both:

- The first two weeks back are typically the hardest. I may be a little slower than usual. I'd appreciate your patience as I get back up to speed.
- I'd like to be on calendar for the most important meetings, but I'm asking to skip recurring meetings that don't require my presence for the first two weeks.
- [If pumping: I'll need three short breaks a day for pumping. I'll add them as recurring blocks. They are legally protected, but more importantly, they're short and not negotiable.]
- I'll do my best work on focused tasks, less great on rapid context-switching the first weeks.

What I'd appreciate from you:

- Direct feedback if something is not working. I'd rather know early.
- Patience on response times my first 2 weeks.
- Clarity on what's high priority and what can wait.

Does that work? Anything you'd like to add?"

Script 3, the manager who has been less than supportive

"I want to be clear about a few things ahead of the return.

I'm returning on _____. The protections I have around lactation breaks, doctor's appointments related to postpartum, and reasonable accommodation are in place under [federal law, state law, or company policy , you fill in what applies].

I'd prefer to handle this collaboratively. What I'm asking for is:

- A calendar that allows for pump breaks at roughly _____, _____, _____.
- The first two weeks at a slightly reduced meeting load.
- Communication through email or chat when possible, so I have written records of expectations.

If there's a concern about my work, I'd like to discuss it directly. If there isn't, I'd appreciate the support to make this transition successful."

(This one is for the situation where you may need a paper trail. It is firm but not aggressive. If the response is hostile, your next conversation is with HR, and you should keep notes.)

The first-day-back plan

What the first day actually looks like.

The morning of

THE NIGHT BEFORE

- ☐ Pack the bag tonight (not at 6am tomorrow)
- ☐ Lay out clothes
- ☐ Confirm the daycare drop-off plan
- ☐ Set two alarms
- ☐ Talk to the partner about the morning split
- ☐ Eat dinner sitting down

THE MORNING OF

- ☐ Wake at the same time you would on a normal work day
- ☐ Coffee while feeding the baby OR coffee before
- ☐ Eat breakfast. The first day at the desk is not the day to skip breakfast.
- ☐ Allow yourself an extra 30 minutes for the unexpected thing (a blow-out diaper, the keys lost, the baby crying at the door)

The drop-off

THE DROP-OFF SCRIPT

To the caregiver:

"I've packed everything in the bag. The handoff sheet is in the front pocket. If anything comes up, my work number is on the sheet. I'll be there at pickup at ____."

To the baby:

"Mama is going to work. I'll see you at ____ o'clock.
I love you. Have a fun day."

To yourself:

"I am going to walk to the car without looking back.
If I look back, I will not be able to leave."

The drive in

If you cry, you cry. That is normal. It happens to a lot of mothers on day one. It doesn't mean anything is wrong.

What helps:

- A specific podcast or playlist (not something that will make you cry harder)
- Calling a friend who has done this before
- Not calling the caregiver every ten minutes (set a "I won't check until lunch" rule, ish)

The first hour at the desk

- ☐ Don't open all the emails at once. Open three at a time. Triage.
- ☐ Find the bathroom. Find the pump room (if applicable). Find the coffee.
- ☐ Say hello to whoever you'd normally say hello to.
- ☐ Let them ask the baby questions briefly, then redirect. ("She's great. How was your year? What's been on fire?")
- ☐ The work will still be there. Don't try to "catch up" in the first hour. You will not.

The first day, end-of-day check-in

Before you leave:

- ☐ One task I actually finished today: _____
- ☐ One thing I want to follow up on tomorrow: _____
- ☐ One thing I learned: _____
- ☐ How am I, on a scale of 1-10 (no judgment): ____
- ☐ What do I need to bring with me tomorrow that I didn't have today: _____

The new morning routine

A page for reverse-engineering from “what time do I need to leave” backward.

THE CURRENT MORNING ROUTINE (PRE-WORK)

WE LEAVE THE HOUSE AT: ____ AM

DAYCARE / NANNY ARRIVAL TIME: ____ AM

I NEED TO BE AT THE DESK AT: ____ AM

WORKING BACKWARD, 15-MIN BLOCKS:

- ____ AM Leave the house
- ____ AM Final check (keys, phone, bag, milk if pumping)
- ____ AM Get baby in car seat / stroller
- ____ AM Final diaper change
- ____ AM Pack the day bag
- ____ AM Eat breakfast (sitting down)
- ____ AM Get dressed
- ____ AM Bottle / morning feed
- ____ AM Shower (if you shower in the morning)
- ____ AM Coffee
- ____ AM Wake up

THE FIRST-WEEK ADJUSTMENT (you will need 30-45 more minutes than you think)

Original wake-up time + 30 minutes = your new wake-up

WHAT THE PARTNER (IF ANY) HANDLES:

WHAT I HANDLE:

THE BACKUP IF SOMETHING GOES SIDEWAYS

(spilled milk, blowout, lost keys, sick baby):

The new evening routine

Same approach, backwards.

THE CURRENT EVENING ROUTINE

THE BABY GOES TO BED AT: ____ PM

I GET HOME AT: ____ PM

WORKING BACKWARD, 15-MIN BLOCKS:

- ____ PM Bedtime (lights out)
- ____ PM Story / song
- ____ PM Pajamas / teeth
- ____ PM Bath (every other night, or daily)
- ____ PM Dinner with the baby
- ____ PM Walk or movement, if possible
- ____ PM Pickup from daycare / handoff
- ____ PM Leaving work

WHAT THE PARTNER (IF ANY) HANDLES:

WHAT I HANDLE:

THE 30-MINUTES-AFTER-BABY-IS-DOWN PLAN (this is YOUR time, even if you spend it on dishes)

THE 30-MINUTES-BEFORE-MY-OWN-SLEEP PLAN (this is the wind-down. Protect it.)

The “I am also a different worker now” page

A page to read once.

You are not the same worker you were a year ago. This is not a deficit. It is information.

What may have shifted

- **Your bandwidth.** Less context-switching tolerance. More focused-task capacity.
- **Your values.** A meeting that doesn’t matter feels different now. Sentences like “let’s circle back” register as cost, not norm.
- **Your patience.** Both directions. Less patience for office politics. More patience for the actual hard problems.
- **Your priorities.** The 7pm “urgent” email is now genuinely not as urgent. The pediatrician’s appointment is.
- **Your speed.** May be slower in raw output. Often faster at sensing what actually matters.

What that means, practically

- You may be a better worker in some ways. (Sharper. Less interested in performance work.)
- You may be a worse worker in others. (Less available at 8pm. Less interested in three-hour meetings.)
- The combination is real. The combination is what you bring.

What to do about it

- Don’t apologize for the changes. The work was already a system. Now it has new constraints. That’s the data.

- Renegotiate scope where you can. "This used to be a 3-month project. With my current capacity, it's a 4-month project. Or, with extra help, it's still 3."
- Identify the work that is uniquely you. Lean into that. Hand off the work that is not.
- Notice which colleagues now drain you and which energize you. The list may have shifted.

The first-week check-in

Five lines a day, for five days.

DAY 1 _____

What was hardest: _____

What surprised me: _____

What I want for tomorrow: _____

DAY 2 _____

What was hardest: _____

What surprised me: _____

What I want for tomorrow: _____

DAY 3 _____

What was hardest: _____

What surprised me: _____

What I want for tomorrow: _____

DAY 4 _____

What was hardest: _____

What surprised me: _____

What I want for tomorrow: _____

DAY 5 _____

What was hardest: _____

What surprised me: _____

What I want for next week: _____

THE WEEK IN ONE SENTENCE:

THE THING I WANT MORE OF NEXT WEEK:

THE THING I WANT LESS OF NEXT WEEK:

The thirty-day check-in

A wider lens.

30 DAYS BACK / DATE _____

THE WORK

What I'm doing well:

What I'm struggling with:

What I need from my manager that I haven't asked for:

What I'm proud of:

THE BODY

How am I sleeping (1-10): ____

How am I eating (circle): not enough / fine / too much

How is my supply, if relevant: _____

Postpartum recovery feels (circle): improving /
flat /
worse

THE HOME

How is the morning routine (1-10): ____

How is the evening routine (1-10): ____

What's not working: _____

What we want to try next month: _____

THE BABY

How are they doing at daycare / with nanny:

What I've noticed about them since I went back:

ME, IN ONE WORD

The ninety-day check-in

The decision page.

90 DAYS BACK / DATE _____

THE FUNDAMENTAL QUESTION

Is this sustainable?

- ☐ Yes, mostly. Some tweaks needed.
- ☐ Yes, with significant changes.
- ☐ No, not in current form.

WHAT IS SUSTAINABLE

WHAT IS NOT

WHAT I WANT TO ASK FOR

- ☐ Hours change (full-time → reduced, or vice versa)
- ☐ Role change
- ☐ Location change (remote / hybrid / in-office)
- ☐ Team change
- ☐ Compensation reset
- ☐ Specific accommodation: _____

WHO I NEED TO HAVE THE CONVERSATION WITH

1. _____
2. _____

WHAT I WILL DO IF THE ASK IS DENIED

WHAT I'M LEARNING ABOUT MYSELF AS A WORKING PARENT

A “this isn’t working” page

A page that doesn’t assume you’ll stay. Honest options.

If, after 90 days, you’ve decided the current setup isn’t working, your options include:

Negotiation

Most arrangements can be renegotiated. Hours. Days. Remote vs in-office. Scope. Team. Sometimes the company will surprise you. Often they would rather adjust than lose you.

THE NEGOTIATION ASK, IN ONE PARAGRAPH

"I've spent the first 90 days back evaluating what's working and what isn't. The thing that isn't working is _____. The change I'd like to propose is _____. Here is how I think it would work, and here is the impact on the business: _____

I'm happy to discuss alternatives. I'm asking for this to make my work here sustainable, which is in both our interests."

Reducing scope

You may not need to leave the job. You may need to reduce the job.

- Drop a project, even if no one has officially said you can.
- Decline a meeting series, with a polite explanation.
- Push back on the “urgent” that isn’t actually urgent.

Switching internally

A different role, in the same company. Often a much easier transition than leaving. Often the path many returning parents take.

Leaving

It is allowed. It is not a failure. It is a reasonable response to a job that does not fit the parent you have become.

If you decide to leave:

- Give appropriate notice. Two weeks if you have a normal relationship. Longer if you have a leadership role. Shorter if the workplace has been hostile.
- Take the PTO you've accrued before you leave (in many states this is paid out anyway).
- Continue health insurance via COBRA if needed.
- Don't burn bridges. The world is small. The person you yelled at in your exit interview will show up again in five years.

Going freelance / consulting

For some, this becomes the version of "work" that actually fits. Flexible hours. Project-based. Higher hourly rate. Less benefits.

This deserves its own conversation, often with an accountant. Worth exploring before deciding.

Staying home for a stretch

Also a real option. Not a failure. Not a regression. A legitimate choice that many parents make for some period of time. Often with a return-to-paid-work plan eventually.

If this is the choice:

- Talk to a financial advisor before, not after.
- Plan for the gap on a resume. There are ways to talk about it.
- Stay in touch with your network. The hardest part of returning later is the network, not the skills.

A page for the partner

If you have one, this is the conversation that needs to happen BEFORE the first day, not after.

THE LOAD CONVERSATION

WHAT THE FIRST 30 DAYS LOOK LIKE

I am returning to work on _____.

I will be working ____ hours / day, ____ days / week.

I will be ____ (home, in office, hybrid: ____ days).

WHAT I NEED FROM YOU, NON-NEGOTIABLE

- ☐ Morning drop-off ____ days / week
- ☐ Evening pickup ____ days / week
- ☐ Solo bedtime ____ nights / week
- ☐ Owning the doctor / daycare relationship for ____
- ☐ Owning the household task of _____
- ☐ Backup plan when I am late / sick / overloaded

WHAT I WILL HANDLE

- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____

THE FIRST-30-DAY RULE

The first 30 days, neither of us makes any "we should change ____" decisions about household labor. We just notice what's hard. After 30 days, we have one conversation, with this list out, and we adjust.

THE COMMUNICATION CHANNEL

Daily, at ____:____ pm: 10 minutes, just us, to check in on logistics for the next day. Phones down. Not in the kid's earshot.

THE WEEKLY CHECK-IN

Every Sunday, ____ pm: 30 minutes. Whole week ahead. Calendar review. Childcare review. Anything that

might fall.

A small final note

A page to read on a hard day.

Returning to work after a baby is one of the harder things our culture asks of us, and asks it largely without scaffolding. Most of the people in your office have not done what you are doing.

You are not behind. You are not weaker. You are doing the work of two roles, in parallel, with one body, on broken sleep.

Three months from now, the routine will mostly settle. Six months from now, you will not believe how hard the first three were.

In the meantime: take the small care. Eat at lunch, sitting down. Go to the bathroom when you need to. Drink water. Step outside once a day, even briefly.

The work will still be there.

Soothemade.

Numbers to keep

MANAGER

Name: _____ Number: _____

HR / BENEFITS CONTACT

Name: _____ Number: _____

CHILDCARE PRIMARY

Name: _____ Number: _____

CHILDCARE BACKUP

Name: _____ Number: _____

PEDIATRICIAN

Name: _____ Number: _____

A SAFE COLLEAGUE I CAN TEXT FROM THE BATHROOM

Name: _____ Number: _____

US WAGE AND HOUR DIVISION (federal protections)

1-866-487-9243 (Mon-Fri)

US MATERNAL MENTAL HEALTH HOTLINE

1-833-852-6262 (24/7, free, confidential)



From *Soothemade Notes*, a small apothecary of printables, planners, and cards for the unphotographed parts of new parenthood. Made slowly, in plain language.



Soothemade *Notes*

*Made for the version of you no one tells you about, the
one at four in the morning, the one in the parking lot, the
one who doesn't recognize her own week.*

notes.soothemade.com

Personal use only. Not for redistribution.
© 2026 Soothemade · made slowly, in plain language